

VSCode + Claude Code

Free Setup Using NVIDIA NIM — Step by Step Guide for Beginners

✓ 100% Free

✓ No Credit Card

✓ Cloud Speed

✓ Beginner Friendly

What You Need First — Install These Before Starting

Tool	Download	Purpose
Node.js	nodejs.org	Required to run Claude Code
Git	git-scm.com	Clone the proxy from GitHub
Python 3.11+	python.org	Runs the free proxy server
VSCode	code.visualstudio.com	Your code editor

Part 1 — Get Your Free NVIDIA API Key

1 Create a Free NVIDIA Account

Go to **build.nvidia.com** → Click **Sign Up** → Create your account. No credit card required.

2 Generate Your API Key

After login, go to this URL:

```
build.nvidia.com/settings/api-keys
```

Click **Create API Key** → Copy it. It looks like this:

```
nvapi-xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx
```

■ *This key is shown only once. Save it before closing the page.*

Part 2 — Install Claude Code

3 Install Claude Code via NPM

Open PowerShell or Command Prompt and run:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Part 3 — Set Up the Free Proxy

4 Install uv + Python 3.14

Run these 3 commands one by one in PowerShell:

```
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -c "irm https://astral.sh/uv/install.ps1 | iex"
uv self update
uv python install 3.14
```

5 Clone the Proxy Repository from GitHub

This downloads the free proxy to your computer:

```
git clone https://github.com/Alishahryar1/free-claude-code
cd free-claude-code
```

6 Configure Your .env File

Inside the **free-claude-code** folder → find **.env.example** → copy it → rename to **.env** → open in Notepad and paste:

```
NVIDIA_NIM_API_KEY="nvapi-your-key-here"

MODEL_OPUS="nvidia_nim/moonshotai/kimi-k2-thinking"
MODEL_SONNET="nvidia_nim/mistralai/devstral-2-123b-instruct-2512"
MODEL_HAIKU="nvidia_nim/moonshotai/kimi-k2.5"
MODEL="nvidia_nim/moonshotai/kimi-k2.5"

NIM_ENABLE_THINKING=false
```

■ Replace 'nvapi-your-key-here' with your actual NVIDIA API key, then save the file.

Part 4 — Install Claude Code Extension in VSCode

7 Install the Claude Code Extension

- 1 Open VSCode
- 2 Press Ctrl + Shift + X to open Extensions panel
- 3 Type "Claude Code" in the search box
- 4 Click Install and wait for it to finish

Part 5 — Launch Everything

8 Start the Proxy — Open Terminal 1

Open PowerShell or CMD outside VSCode and run:

```
cd free-claude-code
uv run python server.py
```

■ You should see: 'Server running on http://localhost:8082' — keep this window open the whole time you work.

9 Launch Claude Code Inside VSCode — Terminal 2

Open your project folder in VSCode → Press **Ctrl + `** (backtick) to open integrated terminal → Run all 3 lines:

```
$env:ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL="http://localhost:8082"
$env:ANTHROPIC_AUTH_TOKEN="freec"
claude
```

■ All 3 lines must be run in the SAME terminal window, one after another. Do NOT close Terminal 1.

Every Day — Quick Launch Cheatsheet

Terminal 1 — Start Proxy First	Terminal 2 — Launch Claude Code in VSCode
<pre>cd free-claude-code uv run python server.py</pre>	<pre>\$env:ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL="http://localhost:8082" \$env:ANTHROPIC_AUTH_TOKEN="freec" claude</pre>

Troubleshooting — Common Errors

Error	Fix
Auth conflict / subscription prompt	Run 'claude logout' in terminal first, then redo Step 9
401 Unauthorized	Close all terminals. Start fresh from Step 8. Proxy must be running before you launch claude.
Port 8082 already in use	Run: netstat -ano findstr :8082 then taskkill /PID [number] /F
On Mac or Linux	Replace \$env:VARIABLE='value' with: export VARIABLE='value'
Slow response	Type /model haiku inside Claude Code for faster replies